

THE CHALLENGER

Gaurav Gogoi, 43, Congress
Deputy Leader of Lok Sabha

KEY STRATEGIES

- The six-party alliance aims to pool fragmented opposition votes
- Five targeted promises—monthly cash transfers to women, universal health cover, monthly pension for senior citizens, land rights for indigenous people and justice for Zubeen Garg within 100 days
- Building a campaign around the 'Bor Asom' vision of an inclusive Assam. Promised law against communal targeting of a group
- It's pushing allegations of corruption involving Sarma and his wife
- Converting public grief over Zubeen Garg's death into anti-incumbency vote by amplifying the conspiracy theory around the icon's demise

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Orunodoi scheme (a poverty alleviation initiative) and self-employment support for one million people. Congress's counter are five promises aimed at women, the elderly, indigenous groups and Gen Z: unconditional monthly cash transfers of Rs 50,000 to women to start businesses, Rs 25 lakh health cover, a Rs 1,250 monthly pension and a dedicated ministry for senior citizens, land rights for one million indigenous people, and justice for Assam's deceased musical icon Zubeen Garg within 100 days.

And then there is the immigration question. The spectre of demographic change, of Bangladeshi encroachment eroding Assamese language and culture, is among the most emotionally charged issues in the state. In the manifesto, the BJP offers identity-protection tools—Uniform Civil Code, action against 'love jihad' and 'land jihad', implementation of the Immigrants (Expulsion from Assam) Act. Sarma's constant invocations of 'Miyas' have stoked anxiety among indigenous voters and worked to arrest the fragmentation of Hindu and tribal votes along ethnic lines.

Layered over Sarma's personal appeal is the organisational machinery of the BJP-RSS and the party's financial muscle, which carries its four-pillar narrative to every prospective voter. The Congress remains weak at the booth level even as the BJP's grassroots penetration has deepened with every election cycle.

The Fightback

Buoyed by his surprise Lok Sabha victory in 2024, despite an intense campaign mounted by Sarma and his cabinet colleagues, the Congress appointed 43-year-old Gaurav Gogoi as state unit president in May last year, less than a year before the election. The compressed timeline, combined with the discomfort of veteran Congressmen with a leader a generation younger, has made his position precarious.

Yet Gaurav has stitched together a six-party Congress-led alliance, including Asom Sonmilito Morcha (ASM) comprising Akhil Gogoi's Raijor Dal and Lurinjyoti Gogoi's Asom Jatiya Parishad (AJP), with Gaurav himself declared as the CM candidate. Among anti-BJP voters, there is genuine hope that the convergence of the three Gogois will consolidate the Ahom vote in upper Assam, a region of 27 seats. Sarma's identity as a Brahmin from lower Assam is a friction point in upper Assam, where Ahom voters generated significant swings in at least eight assembly seats in previous elections.

The Opposition's current narrative rests on two pillars: alleged corruption involving Sarma and his wife, and the chief minister's sustained communal campaign against Muslims. For much of his political career, Sarma has faced corruption charges tied to his family's expanding portfolio—media houses, tea estates, schools, and other businesses. The electoral impact of this, however, has been negligible.

The Opposition also promises Bor Asom, an inclusive Assam where every community finds dignified belonging. It also proposes to counter the BJP's communal politics through legal means, including measures to criminalise the targeting of any community on religious or ethnic grounds. Sarma's response is to reframe that vision as a Congress project to build an Assam for Bangladeshi immigrants.

April 9 will reveal whether Sarma's carefully engineered dominance can translate into an undisputed mandate, or whether Assam still retains the capacity to surprise its most confident architect. ■